leader was prepared to go ahead with the summit. The Cuban crisis, argued Gromyko, had shown the need to build bridges between the two countries. On May 16 Khrushchev wrote to Kennedy, welcoming what he suggested was the president's idea for a personal meeting to ease tensions between the two countries and resolve international disagreements peacefully. He agreed to Kennedy's proposal on the place and time of the meeting: Vienna, June 3, 1961.[8]

Khrushchev proposed a discussion of the peace settlement in Laos, nuclear disarmament, and the situation in West Berlin. Kennedy, badly needing an achievement in the international arena, was receptive. He hoped to obtain an agreement on Laos, where the two countries were backing different sides in a civil war, and regarded a discussion on disarmament as a possible stepping-stone toward a nuclear test-ban treaty, which he had wanted all along. West Berlin seemed a more problematic issue, but there Kennedy decided to limit himself to a mere discussion. That proved to be wishful thinking, since it turned out that all Khrushchev wanted to talk about was Berlin. He wanted the Americans out and, to that end, was preparing a psychological attack on the young president, who was shaken and demoralized by the Cuban debacle. Khrushchev intended to bully him into submission.[9]

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WEST BERLIN, AN ISLAND OF CAPITALISM IN THE EAST GERMAN socialist sea, was a legacy inherited by Khrushchev and Kennedy from Stalin and Truman. The agreement that placed American, British, and French military units in the western part of Berlin, one hundred miles deep in the Soviet-controlled part of Germany, was a product of the Potsdam Conference. It was there, in 1945, that the occupation zones in Germany were delineated. The city of Berlin was divided into four zones: Soviet, American, British, and French, one for each of the Allies who had won the war against Nazi Germany. Superficially, the division indicated concordant Allied policy, but the actual disunity and animosity between the USSR and the Western allies